

Seaside escape: Colombo's coastal life offers a quieter counterpoint to the bustle of its cricket grounds, with the city's beaches drawing locals and visitors alike. PTI

autorickshaws, also cost a lot. Imported from India with the Bajaj badge, tuk-tuks are the lifeline for Sri Lankan mobility. Be it at touristy beaches or town-markers, a tuk-tuk will hover, with the driver eager to drop you. Some western tourists also try a hand in riding the tuk-tuk.

The Sri Lankan currency is weak and one US dollar equals 327 Sri Lankan rupees. It skews the economy but also helps when tourists land, as they bring in the dollars. Most beach cafes will have the menu listed in English and Russian. And safety is excellent as many all-girl groups visit from abroad.

Rain that lingers

Located in the tropics and closer to the equator, Sri Lanka oscillates between heat of the oppressive kind and spontaneous rains that cool the surface. This is a weather ideal for lush green foliage, as chlorophyll and sunshine do a tango, while roots find enough water to quench the foliage's thirst.

A good way to gauge the weather is to just observe the ground-staff positioned on the fringes of every cricket ground. Alert to the skies, aware of wind-patterns and quick to race in with their massive plastic sheets to cover the turf once the skies open up, they ensure the pitch remains dry even if they are soaked to the bone.



Street cricket: A game of cricket unfolds on a Colombo street, with tuk-tuks lining the background, offering a glimpse of everyday life in Sri Lanka. GETTY IMAGES

When there are rain interventions in a match, they cover the entire area, lounge on the sheets, cracking jokes while nervous umpires get twitchy and players shoot the breeze in the dressing room. In the stands, fans, always ready with an umbrella, have their cream-sodas and Ceylon tea. That a passing shower is inevitable is the reigning philosophy in most Sri Lankan venues.

Runs galore

Gill won the toss when the second Test commenced at the SSC on August 23. Like a true-blue sub-continental captain, he immediately opted to bat. His batting mates complied too as India declared at 503 for nine. Devdutt Padikkal's 117 and Dhruv Jurel's unbeaten 115 set the tone.

Padikkal, a left-handed bat

leaning more towards the effective rather than the aesthetic, has an old-world vibe about him. He has the kind of old-world vibe that Cheteshwar Pujara exuded, but Padikkal can also reveal an aggressive veneer in the IPL. Jurel, a wicket-keeper transitioning into the specialist batting zone as Rishabh Pant has secured the bigger gloves, acquires runs at a steady trot but, when needed, can shift gears too.

A 500-plus first innings score, the first ingredient for securing triumph, was etched. India dominant and more so when Sri Lanka replied with 290, an effort largely bolstered by Sonal Dinusha's 103 and Pasindu Sooriyabandara's 80. In a game racing against the weather-clock, Gill had no hesitation in enforcing the follow-on.

A gritty draw is eked out on the final day as Dinusha chips in with another ton, his third of the series. According to the Indian team management, the diminutive Sri Lankan was the thorn in the visitor's flesh. India claims the series at 1-0 instead of the expected 2-0, and a tour to the Emerald Isle winds down.



WATCH OUR
SERIES REVIEW